They are one and the same thing. She does not tuck her politics away. Never. Not even in her dreams."[67] After further detailing her own close reads of Davis's work on the biography, and demonstrating a deep care in its refinement, Morrison concluded her letter with a pointed summary: "1. I find the Bantam report wholly useless to me. 2. I am prepared to cut 200 manuscript pages, re-write a good deal for improvement in style and to add certain episodes that are interesting and amusing. I want to introduce more of the risk and joy in her life. 3. If that is not sufficient I think the work should be either assigned to another editor whom you feel can work with her and do more, or I think it should be rejected completely."[68] Despite her own reservations, which included in this same letter the suggestion of delaying the publication for ten to fifteen years, Morrison continued to push forward by keeping close tabs on the project.[69] By March 1974 Morrison had sent Bantam an updated but unedited manuscript. In April 1974 she coordinated with Random House to move the publication date to the fall, and she worked with Davis in her office or at her home in Spring Valley at least five times from May 1 to May 8 on copyediting the galleys, which were ready for review by the end of the month. As Davis finished her epilogue, Morrison continued to refine final details of the book's design. For example, she coordinated images from Angela's childhood, provided by her mother, to appear with oval edges and black outlines on the book jacket's interior folds. Once the text and images were complete, Morrison sent galleys to media influencers and cultural figures, including Ralph Ellison and Maya Angelou, while coordinating book events through the fall to broaden the reach of the book, which was published on October 28, 1974.[70]

Davis's autobiography, in its final form, reflects the emergence of Davis as a figure presented reclaiming the puzzled and problematic narratives circulating about her life, political identities, and relationships. Margo Perkins highlights the work of Davis and other black female figures of the Black Power era whose autobiographical writing "is marked by both a redefining of the self through a story of the Movement, and a notable uneasiness with the project of autobiography because of the genre's historical emphasis … on heroic individualism."[71] The book is structured into chapters around natural and architectural elements: "Nets," "Rocks," "Waters," "Flames," "Walls," and "Bridges." Prisons and, more broadly, the networks of the criminal justice system and state repression are woven throughout each chapter, as is the ability to work across them.